

OVERVIEW

At their best, classroom discussions offer opportunities for many, if not all, students to share their perspectives and respectfully challenge one another's thinking. But this is easier said than done, and too often classroom conversations don't match our vision of respectful discourse. In this conversation, you'll consider a variety of conversational pitfalls, what they might suggest about our students, and how to address them.

SPARK MEDIA & FOCUS LESSON

Animated Video

Illustration of a variety of different conversational pitfalls, in the lesson [Big Foot Conspiracy](#).

PEDAGOGICAL THEME

Fostering Student Discourse

USING THE CONVO GUIDE FOR A GREAT ROUNDTABLE DISCUSSION

- This conversation is designed for a group of 2-5 educators over 30-60 minutes.
- The Convo Guide serves as an agenda for a roundtable conversation where everyone is there both to learn and to share their expertise.
- Each participant should have their own copy of the Convo Guide and access to the Spark Media.
- Pace yourselves to get through the entire agenda in the time you have.
- Questions aren't intended to have a single right answer; instead, they're designed to spark rich discussions.
- At the end, everyone will commit to trying "one small thing" the very next day. Consider how you might follow up with one another!

OBSERVE

5-15 MIN

- To start, take a look at the Spark Media.
- As you watch each scenario -- *crickets, no explanation needed, leading the witness, pingpong, and echo chamber*-- why might the illustrated pitfall occur?
- How do you think that conversation feels to different students in the classroom? What might those different students be thinking about?

DISCUSS

10-15 MIN

- Considering the reasons students might be reluctant to speak, what are some ways the teacher(s) could encourage more/multiple students to contribute?
- What are some ways the teacher(s) can ensure multiple perspectives are surfaced?
- What are some ways the teacher(s) can encourage students to share their reasoning and substantiate their responses without limiting the voices and perspectives?

RELATE

10-15 MIN

- What does a rich discussion/debate outside of the classroom look, sound, and feel like in your experience? In your classroom, what conversation pitfalls (including ones not illustrated above) most commonly get in the way of conversations feeling like that?
- For the pitfall(s) you identified as most challenging, what can you do in your lesson preparation to better tackle those pitfalls and/or their underlying causes during a class discussion?

...AND COMMIT!

5-10 MIN

- What is one small thing you can do tomorrow in support of those shifts?